



Trip Planning Quick Reference

Pierce County 4x4 Search & Rescue | piercecounity4x4sar.org

EMERGENCY

CALL 911

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

- ☐ **Weather:** Check forecast for route + destination. Pack for worst conditions.
- ☐ **Trail status:** Check closures, washouts, snow levels. NPS and WTA are good sources.
- ☐ **Trip plan:** Leave with emergency contact: route, timeline, vehicle, return time.
- ☐ **Ten Essentials:** Packed and verified. See our Ten Essentials field card.
- ☐ **Phone + power bank:** Both at 100%. Offline maps downloaded and tested.
- ☐ **Vehicle:** Full gas tank, spare tire, tow strap, jumper cables, blanket.
- ☐ **Food + water:** At least 1 extra meal and 1 extra liter beyond what you plan to use.
- ☐ **Clothing:** Layers for 20 deg F colder than forecast. No cotton -- wool or synthetic only.

AT THE TRAILHEAD + ON THE TRAIL

- ☐ Sign in at trailhead register. Note where you parked.
- ☐ Confirm turnaround time with your group -- commit to it.
- ☐ Stay on marked trails. Off-trail = #1 way people get lost.
- ☐ Check your map regularly, not just when you think you're lost.
- ☐ Drink water and eat snacks regularly. Don't wait until you feel it.
- ☐ Pace to the slowest member. Stay together as a group.
- ☐ If weather deteriorates, head back immediately. Don't push it.

COMMUNICATION + EMERGENCY

- ☐ **Emergency contact filed:** Name, phone, and your overdue protocol.
- ☐ **Overdue plan:** 'If I haven't checked in by ____, call 911 with my trip plan.'
- ☐ **Cell phone:** Try calling 911 even with no signal bars -- connects via any carrier.
- ☐ **Text 911:** If call fails, try texting 911. Uses much less signal than a voice call.
- ☐ **Satellite 911 texting:** FREE for all carriers via T-Mobile/Starlink (emergency 911 only). Full messaging: \$10/mo.



FREE Satellite 911 Texting (all carriers)

<https://www.t-mobile.com/coverage/satellite-phone-servi>

WHEN YOU RETURN

- ☐ Sign out at trailhead register. Notify your emergency contact you're safe.
- ☐ Report trail hazards to the land manager. Restock your emergency kit.

REMEMBER

The backcountry doesn't care about your schedule. The mountain will be there next weekend. If you filed a trip plan and you're overdue, we start looking along your planned route. Be there when we arrive.